NGO SUPPORT TOOLKIT · 06

Storytelling and Social Media Guide

Tell true stories that move people to act, without taking away anyone's dignity. Content pillars, a post formula, an ethical storytelling checklist and a simple monthly plan.

Free to use and adapt **For** communications leads and volunteers swkghana.org/support · October 2026

START WITH TWO QUESTIONS

- **Who** do we want to reach: donors, volunteers, partners, the community?
- **What** do we want them to do next: register, give, share, partner?

THE PRINCIPLE

The people in your stories are partners, not props. If they would be uncomfortable seeing the post, don't publish it.

1 Four content pillars

Rotate between these so your feed shows your impact, your people and your purpose, not only requests.

Impact stories
One person, one change. A participant's journey, in their own words, with their consent.

Behind the scenes
Your team, volunteers and partners at work. Preparing an event, a field visit, a planning meeting.

Useful knowledge
Tips, data and how-tos your audience can use, linked to your cause. These are the posts people save and share.

Calls to action
Register, volunteer, donate, partner. One clear ask per post, with a deadline when there is one.

2 The anatomy of a strong post

Hook	The first line earns the next. A surprising number, a question, or a moment.
Story	One person or one moment, with a concrete detail. Specific beats general.
Impact	What changed, in a number or an outcome, and why it matters.
Call to action	One next step, with a link: "Register at…", "Join us on…".

Credit	Tag partners and photographers, and add two or three relevant hashtags.

> **Caption formula:** [Hook]. [One-sentence story]. [What changed]. [What you can do: link]. [Thanks and tags].

3 Ethical storytelling checklist

- [ ] **Informed consent, in writing,** explaining where the story or photo will appear.
- [ ] **A parent's or guardian's consent** for anyone under 18, and the child's agreement too.
- [ ] **Dignity first:** no images of distress used to shock, and no "before and after" that shames.
- [ ] **Their words, not ours.** Quote people accurately and let them describe their own lives.
- [ ] **Protect identities** where there is any risk: change names, hide faces and locations.
- [ ] **Accuracy:** numbers checked, and nothing exaggerated for effect.
- [ ] **The right to withdraw:** take a story down if the person asks.
- [ ] **Credit** photographers, partners and the communities you work with.

4 Photos, video and accessibility

Better photos with a phone

- Use natural light, and keep the sun behind you.
- Shoot at eye level, and get closer than feels natural.
- Shoot landscape for your website, vertical for stories and reels.
- Capture action and faces, not only group poses.

Make every post accessible

- Add alt text that describes each image.
- Caption every video. Most people watch with the sound off.
- Don't put important information only inside an image.
- Use plain language and high-contrast colours.

5 A simple monthly plan

Week	Pillar	Post idea	Channel	Owner	Status
1	Impact story				
2	Useful knowledge				
3	Behind the scenes				
4	Call to action				

6 Measure what matters

Once a month, look at four numbers and do more of what works.

- **Reach:** how many people saw your posts.
- **Engagement rate:** reactions, comments and shares, divided by reach.
- **Clicks:** how many people followed your link.
- **Actions:** registrations, volunteers or donations that came from social media.

7 Free tools and further reading

Canva for Nonprofits
Canva's paid features free for eligible non-profits: templates, brand kits and team design. canva.com

Meta Business Suite
Free scheduling and insights for your Facebook and Instagram accounts, from Meta.

Dóchas
Resources from Ireland's network of development NGOs, including guidance on ethical communication. dochas.ie/resources

Google for Nonprofits
For eligible organisations, including Ad Grants and the YouTube Nonprofit Program. google.com/nonprofits

Ethical Storytelling
A community and pledge for telling stories with dignity. ethicalstorytelling.com

Nonprofit Tech for Good
Practical digital marketing and fundraising tips for non-profits. nptechforgood.com

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